INDIA TODAY
www.indiatoday.in

**CHAIRMAN AND EDITOR-IN-CHIEF:** Aroon Purie
**VICE CHAIRPERSON:** Kalli Purie
**GROUP CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER:** Dinesh Bhatia

**GROUP EDITORIAL DIRECTOR:** Raj Chengappa

**CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER:** Manoj Sharma

**GROUP CREATIVE EDITOR:** Nilanjan Das; **GROUP PHOTO EDITOR:** Bandeep Singh
**EDITORS:** Kai Jabir Friese (Features), Rajesh Jha (News)
**MANAGING EDITORS:** Sunil Menon, Sandeep Unnithan
**EXECUTIVE EDITORS:** S. Sahaya Ranjit, Manisha Saroop; MUMBAI: M.G. Arun
**SENIOR DEPUTY EDITOR:** HYDERABAD: Amarnath K. Menon
**DEPUTY EDITORS:** Kaushik Deka, Shwweta Punj, Sasi Nair; JAIPUR: Rohit Parihar
**SENIOR EDITORS:** Anilesh S. Mahajan, Ashish Mukherjee; MUMBAI: Suhani Singh, Kiran Dinkar Tare; PATNA: Amitabh Srivastava
**SENIOR ASSOCIATE EDITORS:** Sonali Acharjee; KOLKATA: Romita Sengupta; BHOPAL: Rahul Noronha
**ASSISTANT EDITORS:** Zinnia Ray Chaudhuri, Aditya Wig
**PHOTO DEPARTMENT:** Yasir Iqbal (Deputy Chief Photographer), Rajwant Singh Rawat, Chandra Deep Kumar (Principal Photographer), MUMBAI: Mandar Suresh Deodhar (Chief Photographer)
**PHOTO RESEARCHERS:** Prabhakar Tiwari (Chief Photo Researcher), Saloni Vaid (Principal Photo Researcher)
**CHIEF OF GRAPHICS:** Tanmoy Chakraborty
**ART DEPARTMENT:** Sanjay Piplani (Deputy Creative Editor); Angshuman De (Art Director)
Siddhant Jumde (Chief Illustrator)
**PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT:** Harish Agarwal (Chief of Production), Naveen Gupta (Chief Coordinator)

**ASSOCIATE PUBLISHERS**
Vidya Menon (Impact)

**IMPACT TEAM**
National Head: Suparna Kumar (Government & PSU)
Senior General Manager: Jitendra Lad (West)
General Managers: Mayur Rastogi (North), Upendra Singh (Bangalore)
Deputy General Manager: Indranil Chatterjee (East)
**GROUP CHIEF MARKETING OFFICER:** Vivek Malhotra

**SALES AND OPERATIONS**
Deepak Bhatt, Senior General Manager (National Sales)
Vipin Bagga, General Manager (Operations)
Rajeev Gandhi, Deputy General Manager (North)
Yogesh Godhanlal Gautam, Deputy Regional Sales Manager (West)
S Paramasivam, Deputy Regional Sales Manager (South)
Piyush Ranjan Das, Senior Sales Manager (East)

INDIA TODAY GROUP

**Volume XLVII Number 10; For the week March 1-7, 2022, published on every Friday**

● Editorial/Corporate Office Living Media India Ltd., India Today Group Mediaplex, FC-8, Sector-16A, Film City, Noida - 201301; Phone: 0120-4807100
● Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, C-9, Sector-10, Noida (UP)-201301; Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; Mumbai: 022-66063411/3412, Kolkata: 033-40525327, Chennai: 044-24303200; e-mail: *wecare@intoday.com*
● Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, C-9, Sector-10, Noida-201301 (UP)
● Regd. Office: F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001.
● Impact Offices: 1201, 12th Floor, Tower 2 A, One Indiabulls Centre, (Jupiter Mills), S.B. Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai-400013; Phone: 66063355; Fax: 66063226 ● E-1, Ground Floor, Videocon Towers, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi ● Guna Complex, 5th Floor, Main Building, No.443, Anna Salai, Chennai-600018; Phone: 2847 8525 ● 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; ● 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; ● 6-3-885/7/B, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 ● 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058 ; Fax: 2377059 ● 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 ● Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited.

**Printed and published by Manoj Sharma on behalf of Living Media India Limited. Printed at Thomson Press India Limited, 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana). Published at F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001. Editor: Raj Chengappa.**

● INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

SYNDICATIONS TODAY INDIA DELIVERED
For **reprint rights** and **syndication** enquiries, contact syndications@intoday.com or call +91-120-4078000
**www.syndicationstoday.in**




*Photograph by* BANDEEP SINGH

COVER STORY

# AKHILESH THE CHALLENGER

**Can the young Samajwadi Party chief upset the mighty BJP poll juggernaut, bring his party back to power in Lucknow on March 10?**

## INSIDE

**UPFRONT**
UKRAINE CRISIS: WHY INDIA MUST WORRY PG 6
J&K: SETTING BOUNDARIES PG 10

**LEISURE**
BOOKS: PANKAJ MISHRA'S RUN AND HIDE PG 57
Q&A WITH MITHUN CHAKRABORTY PG 64

ABG
28 **THE BIGGEST BANK FRAUD**
How Rishi Agarwal of ABG Shipyard allegedly misppropriated Rs 22,842 crore from a bank consortium

COVID VICTIMS
34 **COVID'S TROUBLED KIDS**
As children return to schools, how do we compensate for two lost years of schooling and childhood?

FAKE CANDIDATES
44 **THE IMITATION GAME**

WOMEN IN OTT
50 **NOW PLAYING HERSELF**

**Note to the reader:** From time to time, you will see pages titled 'An Impact Feature' or 'Focus' in INDIA TODAY. These are no different from an advertisement and the magazine's editorial staff is not involved in its creation in any way.

*Cover photograph by* **BANDEEP SINGH**

INDIA TODAY GROUP

Readers are recommended to make appropriate enquiries before sending money, incurring expenses or entering into commitments in relation to any advertisement appearing in this publication. The India Today Group does not vouch for any claims made by the advertisers of products and services. The printer, publisher, editor-in-chief and the editor of the India Today Group publications shall not be held liable for any consequences in the event of such claims not being honoured by the advertisers.

**FOR SUBSCRIPTION ASSISTANCE, CONTACT: Customer Care, India Today Group, C-9, Sector-10, Noida (Uttar Pradesh)-201301. Phones: 2479900 from Noida, 95120-2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad, and 0120-2479900 from Rest of India. Toll Free No.: 1800 1800 100. Fax: 0120-4078080. E-mail: wecare@intoday.com**

E-MAIL to: **letters.editor@intoday.com** or log on to **www.indiatoday.in**